

His youngest son tried to rush forward to help, but His eldest caught his arm and shook his head. The younger one turned away, red in the face, deeply ashamed but he knew not why.

Their Father wiped His mouth on a towel and continued, "What was I saying? Ah, yes, the digital world, it is a dangerous place. But we must not be afraid, we've never been afraid. Many companies have come and gone, but others have stayed and thrived. If it wasn't for a promise I made many years ago," he paused and shot a significant glance at his youngest, who turned redder still, "we would have been in the thick of it." He looked as if he was about to cough again, but stopped himself with what seemed to be a tremendous amount of self-control.

"I cannot talk for long, it hurts my throat." He looked at his youngest, "Open the safe and copy the contents to that pen drive."

The youngest quickly went over to the laptop and clicked on the encrypted partition, he was about to ask for the password when he noticed that it was already unlocked. With shaky hands, he opened it and found a series of documents neatly labelled, 'M, A, F, I, A, S, A, G, A, S.' The significance didn't escape him. He copied the files and handed the drive to his Father.

"These documents contain all the knowledge that I have gained over the years. It isn't complete, but it should be enough. Pore over it my children, for this holds the key to your future."

His eldest came forward and took the pen-drive, and stepped back. His Father looked each of his sons in the eye one last time and said, "Go on now, time is of the essence. Consigliere Sabatini is waiting for you outside, he has advised me all these years and will do the same for you. Go. I must rest for a bit now." His sons all turned around to leave, but not before kissing His hand. His eldest stopped at the door to wipe away a tear, he had never seen his father look so frail and weak before. It seemed cruel that such a strong man should be stricken so.

As expected, Consigliere Sabatini was waiting for them outside. He was a very thin man with large, round glasses; but wiry nonetheless. He had a certain energy about him that belied his stature. He led them to the library where the Don spent many of the last few months poring over the Internet and dictating the contents

of the files that he now had in his hands. He could hear his mother shouting at the maid in the kitchen and could smell the delicious pasta and meatballs that she was preparing. The Don's sickness had hit her hard, but she hid her anguish by spending more time in the kitchen than was warranted. Still, she seemed busy and the extra food was always welcome.

They settled down in the chairs as Sabatini hooked up the projector and started on the first file. He was all business, brusque and to the point. A very practical man, this Consigliere of theirs, he had his priorities and stuck to them.

Microsoft

"Let's begin with the obvious choice. Microsoft. Here we have a family that's headed by Don Stevioli, though Don Billy Gato is still around giving advice where and when it's required. This family was established in 1975 by Billy Gato and Pauly as a software company. The family has ruled the PC scene



since the days of MS-DOS and the IBM-PC in 1980. Dons Gato and Stevioli have taken the family to great success and if money is any indicator, Don Stevioli is the most successful Don among the Cosa Nostra.

The family has been a very successful one, but that success has been built on the bodies of many a fallen soldier. What the family could not make, it just bought outright and what it could not buy, it tried to steamroll. The family has always been stubborn and simply refuses to see the woods for the trees. Windows has been such a focus for them that they've neglected every other aspect of their business and other families have long since taken advantage and pushed into every other aspect of the digital world.

They've always tried to get a piece of every pie they could find, but lacked the conviction to stick it till the end."

Apple

"Apple, this is one of the most finicky families that we'll be looking at today. Their Don, Stefano, was instrumental in shaping the family and its philosophy. Apple has always had a beef with Microsoft. In fact, Billy Gato was a Capo at Apple before he quit and established his own family. A slight, that Stefano never forgot. His effrontery was only partially forgiven when Apple was in dire straits and needed Don Billy's help to get back on its feet, help which the Don graciously provided.

Apple was the inventor of the personal computer and many other products that are all pervasive in this digital age. Don Stefano was a man with a vision, he was also a man capable of doing anything to turn that vision to reality. Stepping over rivals was never a concern and stealing ideas a way of life, yet, this is the Cosa Nostra and we're all guilty of similar action. Regardless, all the stepping on people's toes, daylight robbery and cut-throat competitiveness resulted in some of the most compelling products and service the common man had ever seen. Stefano's conviction and vision has made Apple the richest of families."

Facebook

"Don Zucchini is the youngest Don here. He's brilliant, but still green around the gills. His idea for a "social" network was one that wasn't well implemented and he's always played fast and loose with privacy. Still, the service he offers is unmatched and the people love it, even if they may not take too kindly to him. Monetizing the very thing that makes the world tick has been the most brilliant idea that anyone's ever had."

Intel

"This was a family that was founded by Dons Giorgio and Roberto. Starting out as a manufacturer of RAM, some smart investments in fabrication and strong arm tactics with AMD resulted in their rise to the top of the CPU market. The family has never really been averse to espionage either and has been sued multiple times on said charges. A whole fleet of top lawyers have kept the family afloat and while they've paid out billions in settlements and legal fees, they've always stayed ahead of the game. Till recently. Intel got complacent and seemingly overnight, lost a large